

Impact: Medium Difficulty: Easy Misuse risk: Low

WHY IT WORKS

People who share credit gain more of it — generosity and confidence are more admired than credit-hoarding. Attributing contributions accurately also builds the loyalty that produces future performance and collaboration.

WHAT IT IS (AND ISN'T)

- Not modesty theatre — the point is accurate attribution, not deflecting every compliment that comes your way.
- Not diluting your own contribution — you can name what others did and still own what you did.
- It is making the true map of who-did-what visible, specifically, in the rooms where it counts.

THE PAYOFF

How it lands: Doing good work near them means being seen — nothing you contribute disappears into someone else's story.

Principle: Credit shared specifically comes back multiplied, because people work hardest for the person who makes their work visible.

What you gain

- Loyalty from the people who actually do the work
- Trust from seniors — credit-sharing reads as confidence, not weakness
- Better information — people bring you their work early when attribution is safe
- A team that repeats the behaviour with each other
- Standing that grows with each round of credit given away

Why most people fail at it

- They fear that naming others shrinks their own contribution.
- They say 'great team effort', which recognises everyone and therefore no one.
- They credit people in private but never in the rooms where it counts.
- They spread credit so evenly that the person who carried the work feels cheated.

CORE FORMULA

Name who contributed -> Name what they did -> Do not be vague

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

The next time you present work that involved others, name at least one contributor specifically before you present it.

BEST FOR

- Leading or managing teams
- Presenting work to senior stakeholders
- Building a culture of trust and recognition
- Any situation where others contributed to your output

METHOD, STEP BY STEP

1. Who — Name who contributed

Say the actual names, early — in the opening, not the footnotes. Credit delivered after the applause reads as an afterthought.

Anonymous: 'The team did a lot of work on this.'

Named: 'Jamie and Priya are the reason this exists — let me show you what they built.'

2. What — Name what they did

Attach each name to its specific contribution. 'Helped a lot' is decoration; 'built the financial model' is credit.

Decorative: 'Sam helped loads with this.'

Specific: 'Sam rebuilt the pipeline that made the analysis possible.'

3. Specific — Do not be vague

Vague credit sounds performative and lands as nothing. Name the two or three essential contributions rather than thinly thanking everyone in the building.

Thin: 'So many people to thank — you all know who you are!'

Essential: 'Two contributions were decisive: Dev's data work and Aisha's client insight.'

FIELD TIP

Credit given in the big room counts double; credit given vaguely counts for nothing.

'Thanks to the whole team' costs nothing and pays nothing. Name one person and one contribution in front of the people whose opinion matters, and both the named person and the audience recalibrate what you are worth. Specificity is what separates recognition from ritual.

Situation: You are presenting quarterly results that rest on an analyst's model.

Don't: 'Thanks to everyone involved — really great team effort all round.'

Do: **'Before the numbers: the model behind them is Priya's work. She found the error that changed our forecast.'**

PHRASE BANK

Shared Credit Phrases · Naming contributors

- "[Name] built the core of this — I want to make sure that is visible."
- "This came from [Name]'s analysis."
- "The credit for that insight goes to [Name]."
- "I could not have produced this without [Name] doing X."
- "[Name] spotted the problem we were about to miss."
- "That was [Name]'s recommendation — I ran with it."
- "Three people made this: [Name] did X, [Name] did Y, and [Name] did Z."
- "I want to be clear: this was a team effort. [Names] did the work."

Credit Framing · Making it feel natural

- "Before I present this — let me name who is actually behind it."
- "I want to start by attributing this properly."
- "The people who made this possible are..."
- "I am presenting but I did not build this alone."

Credit to Their Face · Recognising people directly

- "You made this project better than I could have alone — the model especially."
- "I keep getting compliments on the launch. They belong to you, so I am passing them on."
- "I told the leadership team it was your analysis. I wanted you to know it was said."
- "The part everyone loved in that deck? That was yours."
- "Your fingerprints are all over the best bits of this — thank you."

Redirecting Credit · When praise lands on the wrong person

- "Thank you — and to be accurate, that insight was Maya's, not mine."
- "I will take credit for spotting the talent. The work itself was Dev's."
- "Before that praise settles on me: the fix came from the support team."
- "Half of that compliment is misdirected — Sam built the piece you are describing."
- "I presented it, but I did not build it. Aisha did."
- "For the record: the idea we just adopted came from Jordan, ten minutes ago."

Repairing Missed Credit · When you failed to attribute

- "I presented your work yesterday without naming you. That was wrong, and I have corrected it with the group."
- "I realise I said 'my analysis' when it was ours. I am sorry — I will fix that in the follow-up note."

- "You should have been named in that meeting and you were not. That is on me."
- "I took more credit than I earned last week. I have told the team the fuller story."
- "I got the praise; you did the work. I have set the record straight."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Vague: 'A great team effort'
Better: I had a lot of help on this.
Best: [Name] built the analysis. [Name] caught the error. I pulled it together.
2. Weak: Taking full credit for collaborative work
Better: I worked with [Name] on this.
Best: Name each person's specific contribution before presenting the work.
3. Weak: Over-crediting: spreading it so thin no one seems particularly important
Better: A lot of people were involved.
Best: Name the two or three people whose contribution was most essential. Be specific.

DECISION TREE

If You are presenting work that involved others

Name contributors before or during the presentation.

"[Name] built the core of this — I want to make sure that is visible before we get into it."

If Someone else took the credit for your work

Name your contribution clearly and without aggression.

"I built the analysis behind that — I wanted to mention it for the record."

If You want to share credit but do not know the details

Find out before presenting. 'This was a team effort' without specifics is weak.

"Before I present — [Name] did the research, [Name] did the design."

If Credit-sharing sounds performative

Be specific. Vague credit sounds like it is for show.

"[Name] specifically spotted the data anomaly that changed everything."

SCENARIOS

Presenting to leadership on a team project

Name contributors in the opening. — "Before I walk you through this — [Name] built the financial model and [Name] led the research."

Receiving praise for a project that was collaborative

Redirect the credit to the team member who did the work. — "Thank you — though I want to make sure [Name] gets that credit. They drove this."

In a meeting where someone's contribution is being overlooked

Name it directly. — "I want to note that the idea we just discussed came from [Name]."

Writing a report on collaborative work

Name contributors explicitly in the document, not just in the acknowledgements. — "The analysis in section 3 was built by [Name]. The recommendations in section 5 draw on [Name]'s research."

WORKED EXAMPLE

Without the technique

You: (presenting) I worked on this for three months and I'm proud of what I achieved.

(Collaborators notice the erasure. Trust drops. They are less invested next time.)

With the technique

You: The results came from the whole team — Jamie's analysis and Sam's design work were critical. I steered the project but I did not do this alone.

(Collaborators feel seen. They work harder for you next time.)

COMMON MISTAKES

The vague team-effort line

Sounds like: 'Massive team effort, everyone was amazing.'

Better: '[Name] built the model, [Name] found the flaw, and I pulled the story together.'

Credit as afterthought

Sounds like: '...oh, and thanks to the team, obviously.' — as the meeting ends

Better: Name contributors in the opening, before the content — where the attention is.

Private-only credit

Sounds like: Warm words one-to-one, silence in the rooms that matter

Better: 'I want this room to know: section three is entirely [Name]'s work.'

Absorbing misdirected praise

Sounds like: 'Thank you very much.' — for work that was mostly someone else's

Better: 'Thank you — and the person who actually cracked it is [Name].'

Erasing yourself entirely

Sounds like: 'Oh, I did nothing really, it was all them.'

Better: 'They did the analysis; I shaped the recommendation. Both parts are true.'

READING THE ROOM

Signs it is working

- Team members feel seen and valued.
- You are trusted more by senior stakeholders, not less.
- A culture of recognition spreads.
- You feel clean about how you represent your work.

Signs to adjust

- Credit is given so broadly it loses meaning.
- You are sharing credit performatively but not actually recognising the work.
- Credit-sharing is upsetting contributors who wanted to be acknowledged differently.
- You are over-sharing credit on work that was genuinely yours.

WHEN NOT TO USE

- When your individual contribution needs to be visible for legitimate reasons — e.g. a performance review where your specific work must be legible.
- When sharing credit for something that went wrong — ownership of failure is different from shared credit for success.
- When attributing credit to someone who did not contribute confuses accountability.

RECOVERY LINES

Best line: 'I presented that as mine and it was ours. Let me correct the record.'

- "I presented that as mine and it was ours. Let me correct the record."
- "I missed naming you in the meeting — I have sent a note fixing that."
- "The praise came to me and should have gone to you. I am redirecting it now."
- "I said 'team effort' when I should have said your name. Saying it now: this was your work."
- "I have been vague about who did what. The specific truth: you built it."
- "That credit arrived at the wrong desk. I have walked it over to the right one."

TECHNIQUE CHAINS

Presentation chain

Name contributors first -> present the work -> attribute in the moment -> redirect closing praise

Before I start: Jamie built the model and Sam ran the research.

Here is what we found.

This chart — the one that changes the decision — is Jamie's discovery.

Thank you — send the hard questions to me; the compliments go to them.

Overlooked colleague chain

Spot the erasure -> name the contribution -> make it stick -> follow up in writing

One thing before we move on.

The idea we just agreed to came from Priya, earlier in this meeting.

I want the record to show that, since we are adopting it.

I will note it in the minutes as well.

RELATED TECHNIQUES

TC006 — Genuine Specific Compliment

Genuine Specific Compliment supplies the grammar — credit works exactly like praise: named, specific, evidenced.

TC013 — Name the Effort

Name the Effort recognises the labour behind the outcome; Shared Credit makes sure that recognition reaches the right person publicly.

TC004 — Repair Opening

Repair Opening is the move when you got it wrong — missed credit is a small harm worth naming plainly.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Attribution audit

Review the last thing you presented or sent. Were contributors named? Should they have been?

Day 2 — Name before presenting

The next time you present work, name the contributors before getting into the content.

Day 3 — Specific contribution

Give credit that names what specifically each person did, not just that they were involved.

Day 4 — In-the-moment credit

In a meeting, attribute an idea to the person who had it, in the moment.

Day 5 — Written credit

In one document or message, name contributors explicitly in the body rather than only in an acknowledgements section.

Day 6 — Redirect unearned credit

If you receive credit for something collaborative, redirect it to the person who earned it.

Day 7 — Calibration

Did contributors seem to feel more seen? Did your credibility increase or decrease? Did any credit-sharing feel hollow?

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I name contributors before or during the presentation — not after?
- Was the credit specific — naming what each person did?
- Did I avoid vague credit like 'team effort'?
- Did I avoid over-sharing credit so widely it lost meaning?
- Did I redirect unearned praise to the person who earned it?
- Was the credit genuine rather than performative?
- Did contributors seem to feel recognised?